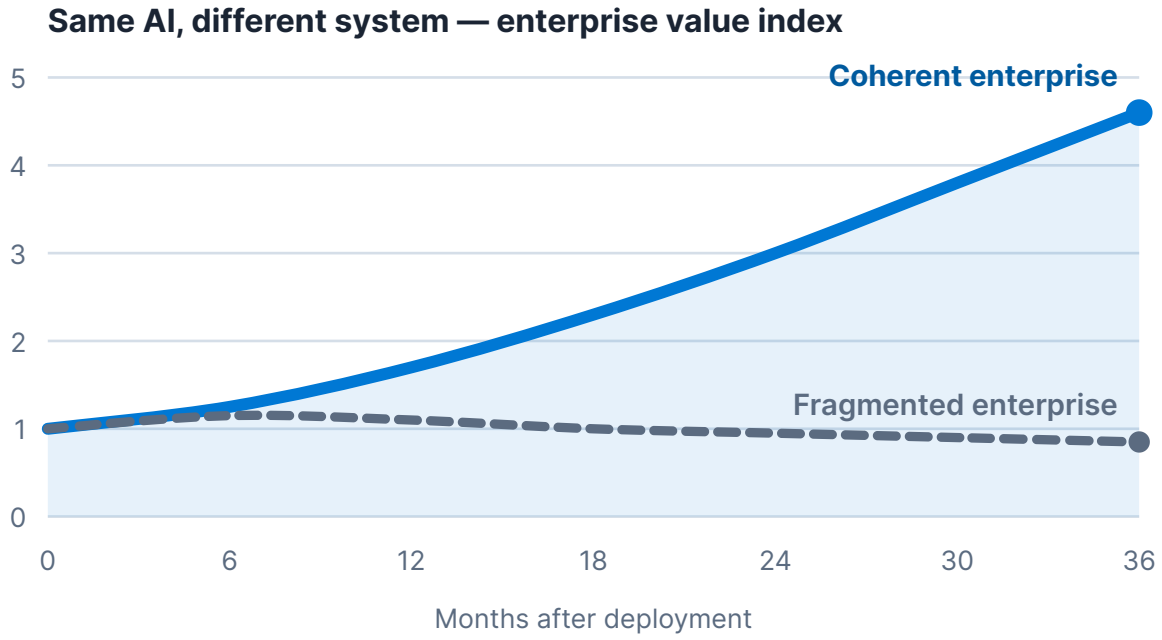
CHAPTER 06 · AGENTIC AI

06

AI amplifies the system it enters

AI brings no way of working of its own. It accelerates the one it finds.

> “The technology is the amplifier; the enterprise is the signal.
>
> INTRODUCTION



Illustrative trajectory, as shown in the book. The technology is identical; only the system differs.

For decades incoherence was expensive but survivable, because competitors carried the same burden. AI ends that truce. Agentic AI raises the stakes from advice to action: an agent that places orders or moves money must know who owns the outcome, where its authority ends and what it may never do. That is why agentic initiatives stall between demo and production — the technology is ready, but the organisation has not yet decided what it is allowed to decide.

Autonomy is earned with evidence

Human in the loop is a design decision, not a slogan. Each workflow step sits in one of three positions. An agent starts supervised and graduates; **it never starts free.**

POSITION 1

Human commands, agent executes

Irreversible, high-value or regulated actions

POSITION 2

Agent executes, human supervises

Reversible, bounded actions on the backbone

POSITION 3

Agent acts autonomously

High-volume, low-risk micro-decisions on verified data

MORE HUMAN JUDGEMENT

MORE AGENT AUTONOMY →

Every agent needs what every process needs: an owner, a documented scope, guardrails and auditability. Agentic AI is **cognitive capital**, not cheaper labour — treat it as ten-percent-cheaper labour and you get ten-percent outcomes.

FOR THE CIO · THE FALSE NEGATIVE

A capable agent fails in a confused environment and the organisation concludes that "AI doesn't work here". **The verdict is wrong, and it costs years.** Build agent governance into the platform, not around it.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ The same AI compounds value or confusion, depending on the system.
- ✔ Agents force the enterprise to write down what it left implicit.
- ✔ Place the human deliberately; earn autonomy with evidence.